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Eiji Kitamura

Clarinetist Eiji Kitamura was born in Tokyo on April 8, 1929. He began playing professionally in the 1950s and was leading his own groups during the 1960s. Eiji has recorded frequently with some of the greatest pianists in jazz, including Hank Jones, Teddy Wilson and John Lewis and has also played alongside fellow clarinetists Woody Herman and Benny Goodman. He appeared at the 1978 Monterey Jazz Festival and has been a frequent guest with Bill Berry at West Coast festivals since then.

Eiji was interviewed in Los Angeles on February 13, 1999, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. At points in the interview Eiji was assisted by a translator.

MR: We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Los Angeles and it's a real pleasure for me to speak with Eiji Kitamura. Welcome. This is my first opportunity to speak with a musician from another country that is a great jazz player.

EK: Oh, I'm really glad.

MR: So thank you very much.

EK: Oh thank you for having me.

MR: I understand you come here every year, for quite a while.

EK: Yes. This year is the ninth annual. It began in '91 and then every year I come to Los Angeles for the International Jazz Party. I am very honored to come to L.A. and play with Bill Berry, and with great musicians all together.

MR: Did you meet Bill in Japan years ago?

EK: Yes. '82, when I went to the Monterey Jazz Festival, and then I met Bill Berry and then, talking about many, many things, and we are very close to each other. And then Bill wanted to come to Japan and I found Bill's job in Japan at the jazz concert/party. And every year he comes to Japan and every year I come to the United States.

MR: Yeah. You take turns and trade off.

EK: Yes.

MR: I understand you went to a university — did you study music in the university?

EK: No, nothing.

MR: Nothing.

EK: In Japanese I studied Japanese literature.

MR: I'm sorry—

EK: Japanese — only Japanese history and literature. Not music.

MR: Right.

EK: And every time I thought about my music, I should have taken it, music. But when I was over 50 years I found a very good teacher of clarinet. But that teacher is a classic teacher. But I need classic, basically clarinet playing, and then I began 52 years old.

MR: For technique?

EK: Technique and how to play clarinet. Only music, very basically. And then basically technique and how to hit notes, and then it was very good for me because I couldn't play high note hits before. But now I can play very high notes, the highest, C and C sharp, D. Very easy to play.

MR: What did this teacher show you to make that happen?

EK: He taught me embouchure for clarinet and how to fit reed and mouthpiece, he taught me. And he taught me the other things. Each woodwind instrument must need good tone, he said. And I learned Mozart, Bach, and many other classic music. It's very good for me.

MR: How did jazz come to you in Japan? Was it through records?

EK: Yes. When I was 14 years old, a young boy, I had one record, an [sounds like] Espy record. My father liked classic music, Mozart, Beethoven and Mendelssohn, the old Espy record, and then I found very small Espy record, and I have that record. I was very surprised at that music. What kind of music, I saw a record label "Don't Be That Way" by Benny Goodman. But only this. And what kind of music — I didn't know jazz. And then I saw a record label, the fox trot, I mean, do you know? Fox trot.

MR: Oh fox trot. Yes, sure.

EK: But when I was 14 years old, I didn't know, what means fox trot? And then I understand that this music, the fox trot. And then I went in school and I told my schoolmates, I heard a very funny music, fox trot, by Benny Goodman. And they were very surprised. And this was my treasured record.

MR: You just had that one, that one record.

EK: Just one.

MR: Was there a tune on the other side?

EK: Um hum. On the other side, something, Benny Goodman trio plays something, the other, a very fast tempo number. But I liked "Don't Be That Way" with orchestra. And then when I was 16 years old, this second war ended. Japanese. And I had the Far East Network Radio, and they used to play jazz programs. And so I must play—

MR: You were hearing lots of fox trots, weren't you.

EK: Yes. And then I knew jazz music, and that I should begin some jazz music. And when I was a child I studied classic piano. And my mother likes classic, my father likes classic, and I played only classical piano. And then I wanted to play the clarinet like Benny Goodman.

MR: So were you self taught on the clarinet then in the beginning?

EK: Yeah. When I was 19 years old I played the clarinet. And it was very funny. My classmate, he got one clarinet, and he couldn't play the clarinet. Many classmates tried to learn to play it. And then I tried clarinet, to blow. "Oh Eiji's a genius." And then how to push key. I don't know, I found only two notes [scats]. Oh Eiji played "Sentimental Journey."

MR: Right. But you could only play the first few measures.

EK: And then my classmates said, "Eiji's a genius." And then I began the clarinet.

MR: That's great.

EK: I think too late. Many musicians began very young, maybe 10 years old. But I began at 5 years old, I played piano, just switched to clarinet.

MR: How did your parents feel about this interest in jazz music?

EK: Oh good, very good. My daddy died when I was a very small boy, and my father said Eiji, you'd better play music if you want. Very sweet. And you choose your future. And my mother said, but Eiji, you'd better go to music school. And then I practiced every day on the clarinet. Oh I don't need music school. I know how to read music, see?

MR: Well you followed in the tradition of many of the great jazz musicians, who basically were self taught also.

EK: Oh Benny Goodman.

MR: Yeah.

EK: My gates. Benny Goodman. And many Japanese said Eiji's Benny Goodman in Japan. But it was very good because they were all very honored — Benny Goodman, my gates

MR: I'm sorry?

EK: Benny Goodman, he's gates of my music, jazz.

MR: I see, yes.

EK: And after that I found Artie Shaw's record, and then after that Buddy DeFranco records, and they were so different. A different experience of music. And then I copied a Buddy DeFranco phrase, maybe five albums I copied all his improvisation.

MR: You wrote them down?

EK: Yeah. And then it was a very funny story. I met Buddy DeFranco. He came to Japan. And his New Gramercy Orchestra, and then I met Buddy and I played old Buddy. "Eiji, are you professional or a student?" "Oh I'm professional." "Oh no. Stop my copy." Buddy says, "and throw away your copied music, all of it, throw away. Eiji, you need your own improvisation. You need your originality" Buddy said to me. And then really I throw away all the music.

MR: To make yourself play your own style.

EK: Yes. And then I met, in '76 he came to Japan. In 1969 the New Gramercy Orchestra and Buddy DeFranco came to Japan. And then after '76 I met Buddy. And he invited — the Yamaha Corporation invited Buddy, and then I played together. And Buddy said, "Eiji, you've got big success. Congratulations." He said to me, "Eiji you have your own style."

MR: Great.

EK: And then after that I played many, many times double clarinet with Buddy DeFranco, in the tour in Japan, Australia, and '96 we went to the Paris and I played double clarinet with Buddy DeFranco.

MR: Why is jazz so popular in Japan? Do you know?

EK: Oh I don't know why, but young men like it as one of the fashion. Jazz is fashion. Many Japanese don't understand jazz, but only fashion. But a few people really understand jazz music. Kind of music — Japanese like all kinds of music. Jazz is only one part. But younger generation like fashion.

MR: Well you were playing out on jobs in the 50s already. Have you been able to make your living as a musician since then pretty much? Have you made your living as a musician all your life?

EK: I think that jazz is my life. Sometimes if I don't have no money, it's okay. But I have good music, good jazz.

MR: Over here we call that "paying your dues." That sometimes you're working and sometimes you're not, but you still do it for the music.

EK: When I play the clarinet, if I didn't take breakfast, nothing, no money, but when I play clarinet, my heart feeling like luck filled.

MR: That's great.

EK: And in 1950, I had a job—

TR: He was cheated by his manager in the 1950s.

MR: I'm sorry, say it again?

TR: His manager in the 1950s was cheating him.

MR: Your manager — oh, oh.

EK: Very bad manager.

MR: You had a bad manager in the 50s.

EK: He stole all the money and ran away. And I had my quintet, I should pay money every week.

MR: You were paying the men in the band.

EK: That manager, ran away, and he stole one year's fee. And then when I went — I got money and paid all my members. I couldn't buy some food, nothing. And every day I ate potatoes and onions.

MR: Gee — I guess you were paying some dues.

EK: But when I play clarinet, my feeling is like my heart, luck filled.

TR: But nobody noticed that, the manager.

MR: I'm sorry, nobody noticed—

TR: When the manager took his money, nobody noticed that.

EK: Many audiences said Eiji's very rich, a rich man. But I don't have money, only potatoes, onions, every day.

MR: In 1957, did you get to play with Benny Goodman?

EK: Yes. On the jam session in Japan. And Benny, I played only one chorus of improvisation. And Benny says, "oh, one more, one more time." And I played a chorus. And I played with many other American musicians, and I'm so excited. And I thought about, my music, okay.

MR: 1978 seemed to be a pretty good year for you.

EK: Yes, and '77. In '77 I went to the Monterey Jazz Festival for the very first time in Monterey. And in '78 I made a record, many, many records, and one of my group, "Swing Session" record.

MR: We have it right here.

EK: Yes.

MR: I thought I would play a piece of this.

[audio interlude]

MR. That's beautiful. I think Benny Goodman must have liked it, I don't know. It's hard to tell what he likes, but I think he must have liked that.

EK: And I'm very lucky, I met Trummy Young — who's Louis Armstrong's old trombone ace, Trummy Young.

MR: Who was it?

EK: Trummy.

MR: Oh Trummy Young, yes.

EK: And he backed me to Hawaii, and I played with Trummy. He taught me many, many things, improvisation, jazz. And then after I met Earl Hines, yes, and in Japan toured together with "Fatha" Hines and his band, and I guest played. And he taught me many, many things. Then after, Teddy Wilson, yes. Teddy was very sweet to me. And Teddy taught me how to make an introduction on the horn, the clarinet. He taught me. And many things he taught me, that any style's okay, in your originality. Bebop's okay, Swing's okay, Dixieland's okay. But you need your originality he said. Never do that copy, he said.

MR: Right. Similar advice you got from Buddy DeFranco.

EK: Yes.

MR: Because he said, "throw out my music, do your own thing." In fact didn't you record with Teddy Wilson? In '71?

EK: Yes.

MR: Great.

EK: I'm very lucky.

MR: Do you perform throughout Japan? Get tours together?

EK: Yes.

MR: Is there a good live jazz scene in Japan?

EK: Yes, very good, I'm very lucky. There are many musicians that know Europe and Japan, but I have a lot of jobs in Japan, and Australia and England, and you know, the Cork Jazz Festival in Ireland. Cork?

MR: Oh yeah.

EK: A very big jazz festival. I went to the Cork jazz festival and the other festival and I'm very lucky. At this time I'm thinking about me, I'm a very lucky man.

TR: His life is [inaudible] that he's so lucky to play at the jazz festivals and jazz shows.

MR: Right. Well I think we're lucky to have you too.

EK: And I need more practice on the clarinet, I must learn whole music kind of music. Sometimes I play a cappella clarinet. Bach.

MR: Tell me about, you played with Woody Herman?

EK: Yes. Woody was very sweet to me. It was very funny, when I came to the Monterey Jazz Festival, I met Stan Getz and Stan Getz, he asked me, "Eiji, do you know Woody Herman?" "Yes, of course, but only know Woody Herman's record and many times on stage, but don't talk to each other." "Okay, I'll introduce you." And Stan introduced me to Woody Herman. Woody is very — his personality is marvelous personality. I mean he has a very good heart and then Woody told me about sometimes playing double clarinet, and you play in my band. And once at the Monterey Jazz Festival he called me on stage and we played together. '72, or no, '82 or 3, and it was videotaped, at the Monterey Jazz Festival. And it was so nice. I'm lucky.

MR: And Hank Jones?

EK: Yes.

MR: Boy, you've played with the best of them.

EK: When I heard Hank Jones the very first time, Hank played with the Benny Goodman Orchestra, Hank Jones. And he played very good. Oh he's the best pianist. But I met Hank Jones. Hank says, "Teddy Wilson is the best pianist." Hank says. But everybody says great musicians, best musician, best musician. But I'm Japanese and I didn't know

jazz, but when I get old now, Hank Jones, Teddy Wilson, Fatha Hines, Trummy Young, many great musicians. I respect all musicians. I need respect.

MR: In Japan now are there radio stations that play jazz?

EK: Very few.

MR: Very few. Just like here unfortunately. What kind of music are the young people listening to in Japan?

EK: Can I say — loud. Loud music. And many radio stations [grunts] just like this. Just like rock music.

MR: Right. Same thing here then. Same thing. I'm glad that we sent jazz out. I'm not sure I'm glad we sent some of the other music out.

EK: And I listen to the radio, only classic programs. It's better.

MR: Did the traditional music of Japan have any influence in your own playing?

EK: Yes, Japanese like traditional and Dixieland, and Dixieland jazz. Many Japanese like Dixieland jazz. I don't know why, but Dixieland is very happy. But mainstream jazz and bebop that's good, but in these days many Japanese like fashion. And after John Coltrane. After.

MR: I see.

EK: [scats] Too much notes.

MR: Too much.

EK: Too much notes, and I don't feel it in my heart.

MR: You'd rather play something that has a nice, beautiful melody to it?

EK: Uh huh. And I heard Benny Carter, only one note enough for me. I respect very much Benny Carter. He has whole things of how to play jazz. How to feel jazz. He knows everything, and he can do everything, Benny.

MR: In Japan can you go to a university now and study jazz?

EK: Uh huh.

MR: You can. They have jazz in the university?

EK: Yes. If possible I want to go to a university.

MR: You still want to?

EK: Uh huh. One more time I want to study jazz, like a beginner.

MR: Really?

EK: No seriously, I think about me, still I'm growing now. And then if it's possible I want to study more.

MR: I see you write some music yourself too?

EK: Uh huh, yes. And I want to compose music, and then I want to play more and more big music, in my heart. I need more. And I met Bill Berry, he knows many things about Duke Ellington.

MR: Yes.

EK: And he will say that Duke Ellington has a very big music. I know. And Bill Berry said, "I want to tell young musicians everything" he once said. That's very good. He's a very nice person.

MR: Really, he sure is. And Ellington had some great clarinet players in his band himself.

EK: Yes. Barney Bigard and Russell Procope, Jimmy Hamilton.

MR: I see you know your clarinet history really well. So when you come over to the states, do you try to bring musicians with you?

EK: Yes.

MR: When you can.

EK: Yes. I want to introduce good musicians. And do you know Jimmy Lyons? At the Monterey Jazz Festival. Jimmy said to me, "Eiji, please introduce a young, good musician," And then I brought many musicians to the Monterey Jazz Festival. My pianist, Kotaro Tsukahara, he's a very good pianist, and he's a home player. I brought — how many musicians, I forgot.

MR: That's good. You're helping other people get into jazz professionally.

EK: Yes. And then now, this jazz party, I can introduce the other young musicians.

MR: When you get together, the group, to play tonight for instance, is there ever any trouble deciding what tunes to play? Or do the people you play with they know everything?

EK: Uh huh. And then I do the program and — this year I brought Eiji Hanaoka, he used to be my student, a very good student, and he plays the clarinet very good, very good clarinet. I want to introduce him to United States jazz fans.

MR: So you'll be doing some double clarinet with your student?

EK: Yes.

MR: That's great.

EK: I like double clarinet. Double clarinet is very good harmony, it makes good harmony. Music is not sports. It's how to play good music with each other. How to make number one in sports.

MR: That's right. Music is not a competition.

EK: Yes. I like it.

MR: That's terrific. What does the future bring for you the rest of this year? Are you going to be traveling more?

EK: Yes, of course.

MR: Always. Always traveling.

EK: Yeah.

MR: How many months out of the year do you usually travel?

EK: Oh, domestic schedule is very tight and maybe half a month I can stay in Tokyo and then half went to other cities traveling. Last November and December I only three days stayed in my home. Just like a gypsy. And I brought along my very big bag and my instrument — every day a changed city. But I'm very happy. My body is very strong, very, very strong. I'm never sick.

MR: That's nice. So you never miss a gig, right? Can you think back, after World War II, there was probably a lot of American servicemen in Japan. Did they bring the music with them? Were they listening to jazz also?

EK: Yes. Many Americans came to jazz clubs. And they enjoyed our playing jazz. And these people, an American musician came to Japan. Richard Wyands.

MR: Richard Wyands, yes.

EK: And he brought his trio and joined my clarinet and a tour in Japan. The very first — I didn't know Richard Wyands, and the first time to join.

MR: The first time you played together, you hadn't even met.

EK: Uh huh.

MR: But the music brought you together, didn't it?

EK: Yes.

MR: Very interesting. Tell me about your latest CD here, that you recorded with Bill Berry.

EK: Yes.

MR: Was this recorded in Japan or here?

EK: Oh here in Los Angeles. With Jake Hanna and Ray Brown. And a young tenor saxophonist, Sam Sadigursky. He was 19 years old. He is very good on tenor saxophone.

MR: And you have your own piano player. Kotaro?

EK: Yes. Kotaro Tsukahara, yes. And the date, it was very funny. Last year I started golf, for my rank and for my health. And then I take a three day holiday, days off. And I wanted to play golf. But I wanted to make a new recording session, thinking about May 15th, next month I have three days off, I should make a new record, a CD. And then I telephoned to Bill Berry, do you have some studio in L.A. I asked him. He said okay, June 11th the studio is okay. Only one day. And I chose the members of the recording musicians. And then the title was undecided. But okay, a title "Jazz Party" title is good. But I don't have music. And then suddenly I write down "Jazz Party."

MR: This is the tune, isn't it?

[audio interlude]

MR: That's great. Are you going to play this tonight?

EK: Yes.

MR: Great. I love this.

EK: These days I have very big jet lag, but not so good improvisation. That harmony is very good.

MR: Do you like to listen to yourself?

EK: No I don't like it.

MR: I kind of guessed you would say that. It sounds like you're always trying to do better.

EK: And I wrote this cover myself.

MR: It's very catchy. It's very beautiful.

[audio interlude]

MR: I see you have a clarinet model named after you? Is that right? With Yamaha?

EK: Yes. I like Yamaha instruments. It's very good for me because Yamaha has many different tone colors it can make. Selmer or Buffet Crampon has its own tone color. But Yamaha has many tones. If I play only the same instrument, the same mouthpiece, the same reed, I can play classic and jazz and Dixieland, any kind is okay.

MR: It's more flexible, yeah. Excellent. Well you're a good spokesman for the company. I'm sure they're glad that you play their instruments. Do you get to play in New York City?

EK: Oh I've never been there. Because once Teddy Wilson, he played [inaudible] jazz clubs, a very small club, and I went only once. And after I went to Toronto, Teddy and Al Bruno the bassist and me, and then I met Gene Krupa and Teddy Wilson and I played the clarinet. I am very excited. And then after, I went to Syracuse and Buffalo.

MR: That's right where we come from, near there. What year was that do you recall?

EK: 1972. And then I went to the Massey Hall in Toronto, and I heard the greatest jazz band, with Yank Lawson and Bobby Hackett and Bob Wilber. I didn't know Bob Wilber, but he is a marvelous player.

MR: He sure is. Do you know Massey Hall is where they made a recording of what they called "The Greatest Jazz Concert Ever" with Charlie Parker and Dizzy and Bud Powell and — who else was on it — I'm trying to remember, but that was quite a famous record. I think Max Roach was on it too. So you were on the same stage all those fellows too.

EK: And I heard The Greatest Jazz Band. And it was so nice. Only my mouth is open. So surprised.

MR: Well it seems like jazz has become a real international music.

EK: Yes. I think I'm lucky because my English, my hearing is very bad. And when I play clarinet, no border of any kind in any country. I went to Sweden and France and England, Ireland and Australia. Any country is okay. It was very funny when I went to Australia I

did a clinic for orchestration of jazz, high school kids. But every time I said my English was very bad, but my music is not so bad, I told the high school kids.

MR: Right. And the music goes right to the heart, doesn't it?

EK: Yes. But I liked that clinic with jazz.

MR: Well I just am so happy to be able to talk to you today. I think this has been really informative for me. And I really appreciate your time. And I'm looking forward to listening to you tonight.

EK: I hope you enjoy it.

MR: I'm sure I will. And I look forward to hearing "Jazz Party." All right. Thank you so much.

EK: Thank you very much. I apologize for my English and my words.

MR: We did very fine I'm sure.

EK: Thank you.